

THE UNIVERSITY OF NEW MEXICO
ALBUQUERQUE

COLLEGE OF EDUCATION

February 10, 1948

Dr. George I. Sanchez
University of Texas
Austin, Texas

Dear Dr. Sanchez:

It is my opinion, based on twenty years of study, that native Spanish-speaking children should not be automatically segregated in separate school buildings from the native English-speaking children.

Such an artificial separation intensifies antisocial feelings in both groups. The Spanish-speaking children become timid and sullen. The English develop false attitudes of superiority. Neither group learns to appreciate the good qualities inherent in the other group. The great democratic tradition of respect for others and the splendid American trait of working cooperatively with others are given no chance to be practised.

Our experience in New Mexico shows clearly that native Spanish-speaking and native English-speaking children will play and work together in harmony if the public school system be developed with that in mind. Both groups should be mixed up together and treated alike. By so doing, we develop Americans.

This general statement does not mean that children may not be sectioned within a particular grade on the basis of performance. It has long been recognized that the pupils within a grade may be divided into small groups for greater efficiency in reading, arithmetic or language. Accordingly, I believe it to be proper to place the non-English-speaking children of the first grade in a separate section for special instruction in English. However, they must be allowed to participate in the general activities of the whole school with the English-speaking children. And as soon as they have an English-speaking vocabulary of some five hundred words, they should be mixed with the English-speaking children in the regular grades and continue with them. Generally, this degree of English proficiency can be secured in one year. No further separation is necessary or desirable.

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If this statement is useful, I shall be glad to have you use it.

Cordially,

L. S. Tireman

L. S. Tireman
Professor of Education

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